

of the Great Wall, created a military organization known as the Eight Banners. In 1644, the decline of the Chinese Ming dynasty led to political chaos that the Manchu exploited, seizing Beijing and establishing the Qing dynasty. It took 40 years of warfare, however, to extend Manchu rule over the whole of China. Originally steppe cavalry fighting with bows, swords, and spears, the Manchu had to adapt to the use of mass peasant armies, naval warfare on river and sea, and an array of Chinese gunpowder weaponry. However, the capture of Taiwan in 1683 by means of a seaborne invasion marked the final triumph of Emperor Kangxi of the Manchu over the Ming loyalists.

In southeast Asia, meanwhile, the warring kingdoms of Burma and Siam were maintaining a very different tradition of warfare, in which armies were based around units of massed war elephants used as a shock force.



▲ EMPEROR KANGXI'S NAVY

The Manchu Emperor Kangxi completed the defeat of resistance to his rule on the island of Taiwan with a victory for the Chinese navy at the Battle of Penghu in 1683.

◀ THE BATTLE OF NAGASHINO

Fought in Japan in 1575, the Battle of Nagashino is famous for warlord Oda Nobunaga's use of firearms. Protected by a wooden palisade, a mass of Oda's foot soldiers firing arquebuses in rotating volleys shattered the charging cavalry of Takeda Katsuyori.

KEY FIGURE

TOYOTOMI HIDEYOSHI
1536–98

Japanese warlord Toyotomi Hideyoshi rose from peasant stock to prominence in the service of Oda Nobunaga. After Oda – by then the most powerful man in Japan – died in 1582, Hideyoshi won succession. Despite two failed invasions of Korea, he remained in power up to his death.



▲ During his reign, Hideyoshi tried to pacify Japan by banning peasants from bearing arms.

